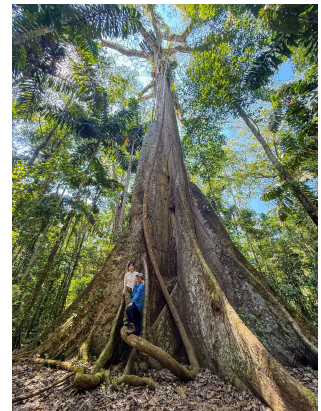


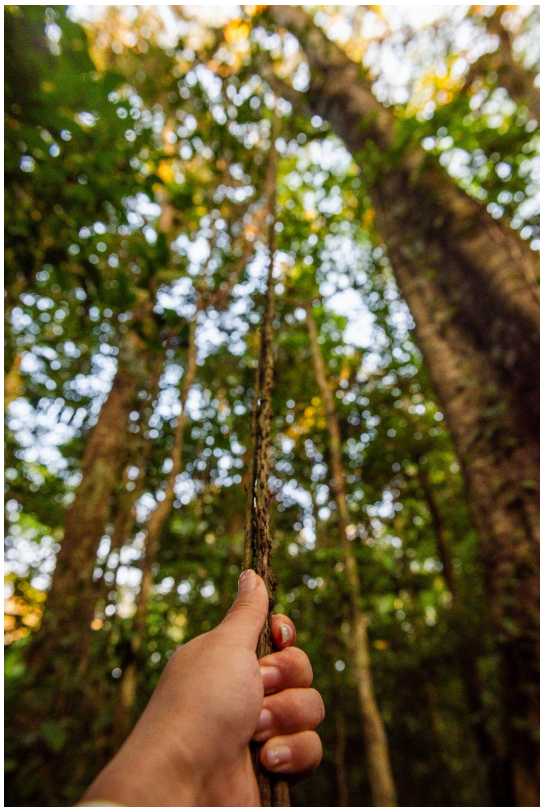


Other plants have evolved different tactics. The walking palm refuses to grow straight upward; instead, it sways its way through the forest, adjusting its posture as it chases the sun. Its roots sprout from about a meter above the ground, and when a better-lit spot beckons, it drops new roots there and abandons the old ones—“walking” step by step toward the light. Its roots are covered in sharp spikes, which locals use as natural graters.

Deep in the rainforest stands a sixty-meter-tall kapok tree, rising like a guardian spirit at the center of a clearing. Our guide told us that shamans gather here to perform ceremonies, praying for the balance of land and life. Because the rainforest offers trees constant rain and sunlight, they do not form



clear tree rings. We will never know this kapok’s true age. All I could do was place my hand against its rough bark and feel the slow, silent breath of centuries.



We gazed at it in reverent silence. Then suddenly, our guide grabbed a thick vine hanging from the branches and, grinning, demonstrated how to “swing from the tree.” I couldn’t resist trying it myself. Hands gripping the vine, feet pushing off, my body traced a smooth arc through the air. Wind brushed past my ears; for a moment I became Tarzan, heart and wind beating in unison, letting out an involuntary whoop of joy.

